Japanese economic slowdown was not known, when China was just a few years into the relaunch of then paramount leader Deng Xiaoping's economic reforms, and before North Korea had progressed in its nuclear and ballistic missile programs, the strategy adopted a more optimistic, if not relaxed perspective on Asia than many subsequent statements of US interest. America's central goals in Asia, the strategy proclaimed, are "to enhance security by maintaining a strong defense capability and promoting cooperative security measures; to open foreign markets and spur global economic growth; and to promote democracy abroad." These goals would be achieved by focusing on strengthening long-standing alliance relationships and other partnerships, maintaining a robust forward-based US military presence in the region, and encouraging the "constructive integration" of China into the international community.[26]

While the overall goals and means in Asia espoused by the US government did not formally change over the succeeding decades, US strategy began to shift in Asia in the 2000s in response to China's rise and more assertive policies, the growing North Korean threat, and the gradual economic integration of the region. Early post–Cold War problems in Asia centered on Taiwan and its moves toward democracy, as early as the 1996 presidential election, which was the first direct election of Taiwan's leader. Beijing feared the potential independence leanings of then president Lee Teng-hui, of the Kuomintang Party, as well as the granting of a US visa to visit his alma mater, Cornell University, and, in an attempt to intimidate both him and Taiwanese voters, fired ballistic missiles into the waters off the island nation in July and August 1995 and March 1996. In response, the Clinton administration sent two US aircraft carrier battle groups to the Taiwan Strait as a show of force. Beijing's naval buildup over the next two decades was designed to counter US strength in waters it increasingly considered its sphere of influence.[27] This modernization centered on what became known as the "anti-access, area-denial" (A2/AD) strategy, whereby the Chinese People's Liberation Army (PLA) began developing a set of capabilities to target qualitatively superior US forces in Asia's inner seas and the